

Pahankanuwa Sermon #11

English Translation

Translated from Sinhala

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(Pahankaṇuwa Sinhala Audio Dhamma Sermon No.)

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

(Homage to the Blessed One, the Worthy One, the Fully Self-Enlightened One)

Pali Stanza:

*Pathavyā ekarajjena, saggassa gamanena vā;
Sabbalokādhīpaccena, sotāpattiphalaṃ varam.*

From:

Verse 178 from the Lokavagga (Chapter on the World) of the
Dhammapada

Dear Listeners,

Today, on this Vap Full Moon Poya day, despite the inclement weather, you have gathered here to listen to some word of the Dhamma—a section of the Dhamma—of the Blessed One. Buddhist devotees expect to listen to the Dhamma in order to obtain some light for their lives, to mold their lives. This human life we have obtained has been introduced by the Blessed One as something extremely rare. Human life is rare; likewise, it is a valuable life. But the value of this humanity is not received automatically. The worth or worthlessness of a life is determined, or decided, by the lifestyle we lead. Even if one lives for a hundred years, if that person spent their life with worthless things, with essence-less things, then that life is entirely fruitless and barren.

Therefore, it is the duty of a Buddhist devotee to live having understood the true values, the true virtues—the real value in a life. Generally, in the world, money, gold, silver, pearls, and gems are considered valuable. But the Blessed One introduced far nobler things to the world through the Dhamma. To understand those values introduced in accordance with the Dhamma and to live accordingly—to mold one's life accordingly—a Poya day is a wonderful, valuable day. It is revealed in the Dhamma stories that even during the time of the Buddha, great lay devotees used this Poya day to make their children understand

and realize the true value of life. Especially at this moment, the background story, the origin story, which led to the preaching of the Dhamma verse we have taken as our topic, is something similar to this.

You have heard about the great treasurer, Anāthapiṇḍika. In this Dispensation, during the time the Blessed One was residing, among the great Buddhist lay disciples, Anāthapiṇḍika the great treasurer was the foremost—worthy of being placed at the very top. He was rich not only in millions of wealth but also in Dhamma-knowledge, and he was a great lay disciple who had also realized the fruit of Stream-entry (*Sotāpatti-phala*), which is considered a noble supramundane state. The mansion of that treasurer Anāthapiṇḍika was entirely an alms-hall. That is, it is mentioned in the Dhamma that it was a mansion that constantly ministered to the Blessed One and the Great Saṅgha, or rather to hundreds of monks daily with alms and other provisions.

Fearing that if his son Kāla spent his time in this manner he would become a wretched person (*kālakappa*), the treasurer Anāthapiṇḍika thought of a device, thinking, "I must introduce this child to the Triple Gem." One Poya day, the treasurer Anāthapiṇḍika called his son and said, "Son, if you go to the monastery, observe the precepts, listen to the Dhamma from the Blessed One, and return, I will give you a hundred gold coins (*masura*—kahāpaṇas)." Then this child made his father promise three times, asking, "Will you definitely give it, Father? Will you definitely give it, Father? Will you definitely give it, Father?" Having made him agree, he then went to Jetavana monastery and observed the precepts. But he had no desire to listen to the sermon. He slept in a corner and returned to the mansion the next morning. As soon as he arrived, the treasurer ordered the servants, "My son has returned after observing the precepts, give him good food and drink." But this child, just as some young children say, declared, "I will not eat until I am given the promised money." Therefore, the treasurer had to give the money first. Taking that bag of gold coins in one hand—holding it with one hand—only then did this child even take his food.

Then, when another Poya day arrived, the treasurer Anāthapiṇḍika thought—by way of adding another part to this strategy: "Son, if you go to the monastery, observe the precepts, listen to the Dhamma from the Blessed One, learn a word of Dhamma and return, I will give you a thousand gold coins." This child, because of his desire for this money, went to the monastery, observed the precepts, and went and sat right in front of where the Blessed One was preaching the Dhamma. He prepared to listen to the Dhamma with the intention of somehow learning just one word of Dhamma and running back to get the money.

The Blessed One saw the mind of this child. Moreover, the Blessed One must have seen that despite leading such a life, there was some power of merit within this child. Whatever the case may be, the Blessed One also employed a certain device—a skillful means, a strategy. What was it? He began to preach the Dhamma in such a way that the child could not grasp the word of the Dhamma. This child was hoping to somehow learn a word of Dhamma, go back, and get the money from his father. But the Blessed One was preaching the Dhamma. This child could not grasp even a single word of the Dhamma; somehow, it kept slipping away. In this manner, the Buddha began to preach. The child was listening with great attention. Why? Because of his desire for the money. However, he could not grasp even a single word of the Dhamma. He failed to grasp the first word of Dhamma. The next one, the next one, and so on, until finally, he had to sit and listen until the entire sermon was finished. But how wonderful was this Dhamma sermon of the Blessed One! By the time it ended, this child had attained that noble supramundane state called Stream-entry, attaining the state of an Ariya (noble one).

But no one else knew about this. The next day, when the Blessed One and the Saṅgha walked to the mansion of the treasurer Anāthapiṇḍika for the alms-giving, this boy followed behind very calmly. Upon arriving at the house, the great treasurer Anāthapiṇḍika offered alms to the Blessed One and the Saṅgha, and prepared to give food to the boy at a seat to the side. The treasurer was astonished to see this child being so calm. The child who on other days said, "I will not eat until you give me the money, the kahāpaṇas," was now eating very calmly. This child also thought, "It would be better if my father did not speak about this money in front of the Blessed One." He felt that embarrassed. He felt embarrassed for having listened to the Dhamma out of greed for money. But the treasurer did not know about this. Therefore, he prepared to bring and give the money next. The child rejected it. He said he did not want it. Because of this, the treasurer said to the Blessed One, "Venerable Sir, my son's appearance—his behavior—is very different today. On previous days, he promised in this way and would not eat until he was given the money. Today, even when urged, he did not wish to take the money." At that moment, the Buddha declared: "O Treasurer, today your son has obtained something far more valuable than this money—indeed, far more valuable than even the empire of a wheel-turning monarch over the whole earth, more valuable than going to heaven, more valuable than lordship over the entire world. That is why he is not interested in that money."

Declaring thus, he uttered the Dhamma verse we mentioned earlier:

Pathabyā ekarajjena

Saggassa gamanena vā

Sabbalokādhīpaccena

Sotāpattiphalaṃ varaṃ

"Pathabyā ekarajjena"—more than ruling this great earth as a wheel-turning monarch, "saggassa gamanena vā"—more than going to heaven, "sabbalokādhīpaccena"—more than lordship over the entire world, "sotāpattiphalaṃ varaṃ"—the fruit of Stream-entry is superior, that supramundane state is superior, declared the Blessed One on that occasion.

Thus, from this, we can understand that due to the efforts of the treasurer Anāthapiṇḍika, the child obtained that state of Stream-entry, which is considered the highest state in the world. This fruit of Stream-entry, this state, is a great change that occurs in the mind. It is called attaining the state of an Ariya (noble one). The freedom one gains by obtaining this state is such that one will never again go to the lower realms in this saṃsāra. The mind never falls to a state low enough to lead to the lower realms. That is the most special strength seen in becoming a Stream-enterer. Thus, if one is to be reborn in saṃsāra, it is at most seven times. If one has obtained the fruit of Stream-entry in this way—to obtain the fruit of Stream-entry means to understand the Four Noble Truths deeply and precisely. Likewise, it means to deeply understand the Three Characteristics in this world—namely, Impermanent (*anicca*), Suffering (*dukkha*), and Not-self (*anattā*). The change that occurs within the mind through that understanding is so great that such a person will never again be born in the lower realms. Furthermore, they will be born at most seven more times in saṃsāra. After being reborn in that manner, they will somehow, in one way or another, attain Arahantship and pass away into final extinguishment (*parinibbāna*). Such a wonderful change occurs in a person's mind through the state of Stream-entry. Therefore, such a massive transformation, a change, occurred in that child named Kāla due to listening to the Dhamma on that day.

What the Blessed One declared regarding the fruit of Stream-entry—its value—as expressed here: being a wheel-turning monarch is a great thing expected by the world, but why is this fruit said to be superior to all of them? Even if one rules the great earth as a wheel-turning monarch, there is still the possibility of going to the lower realms due to the bad kamma one has done in saṃsāra. But the Stream-enterer never goes to the lower realms. That is why it was declared that the fruit of Stream-entry is superior to everything else. The Blessed One has shown the value of this fruit of Stream-entry on many occasions. On one occasion, taking a little soil on his fingernail, he asked the monks, "Is the soil on this fingernail greater, or is the soil of the entire great earth greater?" Then the monks declared,

"Venerable Sir, Blessed One, the soil on your fingernail is very little. The soil of the great earth is far greater." In accordance with that simile, the Blessed One declared: "Even so, monks, for the Stream-enterer, the amount of Suffering (*dukkha*) they have freed themselves from in this saṃsāra is like the soil of the great earth. The amount of Suffering (*dukkha*) remaining, the amount of Suffering (*dukkha*) left to be spent, is extremely small, like the soil on this fingernail." The Stream-enterer receives such a vast freedom. This fruit of Stream-entry is the first of the supramundane states. In this Dispensation of the Buddha, there are four paths and fruits: Stream-entry, Once-returning, Non-returning, and Arahantship. It is through these that one realizes Nibbāna. Finally, through the state of Arahantship, one is completely pacified by the supreme Nibbāna, bringing an end to the Suffering (*dukkha*) of saṃsāra. Thus, the Blessed One declared that even the fruit of Stream-entry is such a noble thing.

Now, it might occur to you: how did this young child obtain such a great thing? One might wonder how he obtained such a noble supramundane state. How did this child, who did not minister to the Saṅgha in that manner and did not even want to see the Blessed One, achieve such a great victory—such a high state—just by listening to a single Dhamma sermon of the Blessed One? This is a good opportunity for us to think deeply. Generally, to obtain such great states—as you, lay devotees, know—one has to practice a lot of meditation. How then did this child obtain it? One might ask, "Was it without meditation?" But, virtuous friends, without meditation, Nibbāna is not found. Now let us examine a little what kind of meditation was present in this child.

Although it is not detailed in this story, we can infer, through certain hints within it, what the meditation in this child's mind was. Regarding everything in this world and this life, there are Three Characteristics that the Blessed One declared. Everything is Impermanent (*anicca*). Everything is, when viewed ultimately, Suffering (*dukkha*). Likewise, everything cannot be taken as "myself" or "mine"—it is Not-self (*anattā*). This is the profound Dhamma that lies here. That is what is called the "Three Characteristics" (*ti-lakkhaṇa*)—the three marks present in the entire world. These three marks do not appear to ordinary understanding. They do not appear to the ordinary worldly person. This appears only to deep insight (*vipassanā*)—to the wisdom that has gone deep. How then did that child obtain this understanding? Generally, this is obtained by meditating according to a subject of meditation (*kammaṭṭhāna*). Now, what was Kāla's subject of meditation? Let us think about it. Kāla's subject of meditation was the words of the treasurer Anāthapiṇḍika: "Son, if you go and learn a word of the Dhamma and return, I will give you a thousand gold coins."

Thus, this child must have gone to the monastery with this bag of gold coins in mind, with the idea, "I will somehow listen to a word of the Dhamma and obtain these gold coins." With a certain calmness of mind born of that, he prepared to listen to the Dhamma. But how did the Blessed One clean up this subject of meditation—arrange it—and bring it close to Nibbāna? Knowing this matter, the Blessed One began to preach the Dhamma in such a way that the boy could not grasp even a single word. Then this child tried to grasp the first word of Dhamma. To him, every word of Dhamma the Blessed One uttered must have appeared as a bag of gold coins. Even to anyone, sometimes what they desire very much appears as if in a dream, doesn't it? If there is a strong desire for something, that is what appears to the mind. Similarly, now, due to his desire for this bag of gold coins, when he sat in front of the Blessed One and listened to the Dhamma, every word of Dhamma appeared to this child as a bag of gold coins. So, he tried to grasp that first bag of gold coins. At the same time, it somehow slipped away. He tried to grasp the next one: "Ah, I missed that one too." He tried to grasp the next. Thinking in this manner, this child listened to the Dhamma preached by the Blessed One, word by word. At that moment, as he went a bit further, when each bag of gold coins kept slipping away, it must have occurred to him: "Not even one of these can be grasped. All of these are passing away. Everything here is Impermanent (*anicca*). Not a single one can be grasped. They come and go. There is only the preparation to grasp a word of Dhamma here."

Now, you might occasionally see banners of white cloth hung in front of funeral houses on the road, with words written on them: "Sabbē saṅkhārā aniccā." Such a word of the Dhamma is written. What is the meaning of this? "Sabbē saṅkhārā aniccā"—"All Formations are Impermanent." "Aniccā vata saṅkhārā"—"Formations (*saṅkhāra*) are indeed Impermanent (*anicca*)." What are these things called Formations (*saṅkhāra*)? In words we can understand: preparations, designs, or constructions. Now let us think about "preparation." After a person dies, if we think of "Aniccā vata saṅkhārā" in a way we can understand: what did this human being do while alive? Everything they did was a pile of preparations. What this person did as their entire life was a pile of preparations and designs. If they did anything called merit or demerit, if they did various things through body, speech, and mind—all of those, when viewed from one perspective, are a vast number of preparations and designs. When reflecting on life, all the activities done from morning till night, when examined, are nothing but a pile of preparations. It is like preparing to go on a journey. Even this inhalation and exhalation, breathing itself—all of this is a pile of preparations. Thus, the only work that deceased person did throughout their entire life—without fail—was breathing. When even this breathing came to an end, all the preparations and designs that this person made to live came to an end

there. They are Impermanent (*anicca*); there is no permanent state. It is so regarding everything.

So, if we consider this child, he was hoping to grasp a word of Dhamma. Later, when he looked, there was only the preparation to grasp the word of Dhamma. He prepared, but it did not succeed. He looked at the next; there too, it was a preparation. In this way, it must have occurred to this child: "This is what is called Formations (*saṅkhāra*). Here there is only a pile of preparations. All of these are Impermanent (*anicca*). These preparations, constructions—all of these are Impermanent (*anicca*)." Because he could not grasp even a single word of Dhamma. It kept slipping away. This was due to a certain device employed by the Blessed One. Through this, then, this child looked at his own mind. What is happening inside this mind? Inside the mind, bags of gold coins are arising very rapidly—thoughts like bags of gold coins. In that manner, the bag of gold coins comes and goes, arises and ceases. When reflecting deeply on Impermanence (*aniccata*), here there is only arising and ceasing, coming and going. Seeing this state, it must have occurred to this child: "These are Formations (*saṅkhāra*)—all of these are just a pile of preparations and designs. They come and go, come and go." Thus, next, the effort to grasp these Formations (*saṅkhāra*) which have the nature of coming and going is that very effort to grasp the word of Dhamma.

After a while, this child must have felt a weariness in this. This effort was proving futile. Not a single one succeeded. Then, after a while, to the point of becoming disgusted with it, to the point where the thought of the bag of gold coins vanished, this appeared as a great trouble. He tried to "grasp" every word of Dhamma, but none was caught. So, as this went on, the child must have understood the second characteristic declared by the Blessed One: "All of these are Suffering (*dukkha*). All these Formations (*saṅkhāra*) are Impermanent (*anicca*). Whatever is Impermanent (*anicca*) is Suffering (*dukkha*)." "Yadaniccam taṃ dukkham"—"Whatever is Impermanent (*anicca*), that is Suffering (*dukkha*)," declared the Blessed One. Then, next, the Blessed One declared another thing: "Yaṃ dukkham tadanattā"—"Whatever is Suffering (*dukkha*), that is Not-self (*anattā*)." It cannot be taken as "myself" or "mine." Perhaps this too became clear to this child. Now, minds like those bags of gold coins arise and slip away. Not even one remains. That nothing remains, that there is no essence or core in any of them, is what is called Not-self (*anattā*). There is nothing to be taken as "myself" or "mine"—nothing to "grasp." There is no core. All thoughts arise and are swept away. Next, the nature of these thoughts was deeply reflected upon by this child. "Here there is entirely a pile of thoughts. They

arise and cease. There is no core. There is nothing to grasp here as 'myself' or 'mine'; nothing to be caught."

The simile the Blessed One has given for this word 'Formations' (*saṅkhāra*) is a very wonderful one. We can easily understand this. The Blessed One declared: "Saṅkhārā kadalūpamā"—"Formations (*saṅkhāra*) are like a banana trunk." You all know what a banana trunk is. Now the Blessed One shows it like a good story. Suppose there is someone who has never seen a banana tree. When they go to a forest, they see a banana tree for the first time. Looking at it, this banana trunk is very straight. They think there is a core inside it. They cut it at the top and bottom and carry it home on their shoulder, thinking, "I can make a wardrobe or a chair out of the core of this." Having brought it home—the Blessed One gives this simile, not us; we are only adding other details to explain it a bit more—he first peels off a sheath of this banana trunk, expecting there to be a core. Next, he sees there is another sheath. There is yet another sheath. One by one, he peels off the sheaths. Finally, he reaches the innermost core. There is only a pile of sheaths. Looking at it in that way, that person realizes for the first time by themselves that there is absolutely no core in a banana tree.

That is the kind of simile the Blessed One gives for this word 'Formations' (*saṅkhāra*). Now we have expressed this in a word we can understand: "preparation," "designing," or "construction." Thus, when reflecting on the things done throughout this entire life, there is such a nature in every single one of them—one thing for the sake of another, one thing for the sake of another, and as you go on looking at each of them, there is no core in any of them. All of them are Impermanent (*anicca*). Because of that impermanent nature itself—now, in the life of a young child, there are wishes and expectations. Whether those expectations are fulfilled or not, in a few days they become a youth. The youth also has various expectations—even before they are fulfilled, they are either destroyed, or, without even knowing it, old age arrives. The old person also has various expectations. Even before they can fulfill them, sometimes, they die. In this manner, the entire life consists of a pile of preparations and designs.

In this manner, that there is no core here, that it cannot be maintained under one's control, must have been understood by that child named Kāla too, through his own subject of meditation—his meditation topic. What was the meditation? This bag of gold coins. Through the bag of gold coins itself, this child must have understood: "Now, other things are just like this too." It is said in this Dispensation that seven-year-old children attained Arahantship. Not by reading books or possessing great scholarly cleverness or degrees. What happens? It is the change that occurs within the mind. This child reflects. If there is a power of merit, they understand a profound Dhamma through a small incident. This is

what must have happened to Kāla too. Through this meditation on the bag of gold coins, because of the method, the manner in which the Blessed One preached the Dhamma, the things relevant to meditation must have gradually emerged for this child through that bag of gold coins.

A point mentioned in this Dhamma regarding meditators is that one must contemplate these things called Formations (*saṅkhāra*) as Impermanent (*anicca*), Suffering (*dukkha*), and Not-self (*anattā*). When speaking of these Formations (*saṅkhāra*)—even though we have given various names to all of these, the meditator reflects on them as Name-and-Form (*nāmarūpa*). When we say Name-and-Form (*nāmarūpa*), we can understand that here there is only a pile of names and a pile of forms. Even though we have placed names in the world calling them such-and-such things, when looking at them from within, when looking at them as they appear to the mind, the Blessed One has shown the phenomena present here in this way: here there is—Feeling (*vedanā*)—there is something called Feeling (*vedanā*), there is perception (*saññā*), there is volition (*cetanā*), there is Contact (*phassa*), and there is attention (*manasikāra*), which is reflection. Feeling (*vedanā*), perception (*saññā*), volition (*cetanā*), Contact (*phassa*), and attention (*manasikāra*)—these five phenomena are introduced as mental phenomena (*nāma*). Now, in the world, we have given names to various things like 'table' and 'chair'. Now we say 'gold coins' (*masuran*). But here, it is not gold coins; rather, ultimately, this is all that is understood by the mind. When reflecting deeply, that child also must have understood: "Even though a name is given in the world, even though they say these are gold, what is present here inside this mind is only this much. There is some Feeling (*vedanā*). Because of the hope of obtaining this, there is a pleasant Feeling (*sukha-vedanā*). Correspondingly, there is a certain perception—that gold, that gold coins are something very valuable. There is a volition—a hope—to obtain them: that thought. When that word of Dhamma is heard, there is a certain impact, a Contact (*phassa*) in the mind. According to that Contact (*phassa*), there is attention—the mind directing itself towards it. Only this much occurs inside the mind." Thus, while the Blessed One was preaching the Dhamma in this way, that child understood, with every word of Dhamma spoken: "This is all that is happening in my mind. There is no gold coin received. There is nothing valuable or extraordinary here. This is all there is." That is the understanding of mental phenomena (*nāma-dhamma*).

Next, what are called physical phenomena (*rūpa-dhamma*)—even though all the things present in the world are decorated with various colors and have shapes and sizes, all of these are constructed and made of the four great elements, which are introduced in the Dhamma as earth (*paṭhavī*), water (*āpo*), fire (*tejo*), and wind (*vāyo*). Earth (*paṭhavī*) is the element of hardness present in this

great earth, in trees, rocks, and so on. Likewise, water (*āpo*)—it is raining at this moment—is the water element. We recognize the water element in relation to the great ocean and water reservoirs. Likewise, the fire element (*tejo-dhātu*)—warmth; the wind element (*vāyo-dhātu*)—air. In this way, this body of ours and other things are things constructed by earth, water, fire, and wind. This is all there is to it. Even if we call it kahāpaṇas or gold, whether it is melted, whether it is red gold or raw gold, in all of these, there are only these four elements. When reflecting on everything in this way, one recognizes: "Here there is only a pile of Feelings (*vedanā*), a pile of perceptions (*saññā*), a pile of volitions—a pile of thoughts and expectations—a Contact (*phassa*), and a reflection by the mind." Next, regarding all other things in the world—valuable or worthless—there are no such stories. It is through the realization that "within everything, there are only these four elements" that one can attain deep states in this Dhamma. This is called contemplating them as Name-and-Form (*nāmarūpa*). Perhaps, in that way, Kāla's warm expectations regarding the bag of gold coins vanished: "This is a futile task." Next, when looking: "What am I doing? While listening to the Dhamma of the Blessed One, I am thinking about these bags of gold coins." Then, gradually, Kāla's desire for that gold disappeared. A weariness, a disillusionment towards these arose. Indeed, what helps one to obtain these supramundane states is disillusionment with saṃsāra. It is mentioned in the Dhamma regarding some who obtained these noble states—like Paṭācārā, Kisāgotamī, and others—that when some terrible disaster occurred in their lives, they then reflected, "This is the nature of the world." Similarly, now, because of this matter, Kāla too understood that these are futile tasks. Understanding this Impermanence (*aniccata*), the nature of Suffering (*dukkha*), and the nature of Not-self (*anattā*), he abandoned his desires for the bag of gold coins.

When he abandoned that desire, then he began to grasp the word of Dhamma preached by the Blessed One. Virtuous friends, there is a great miracle, a great wonder in this Dhamma of the Blessed One. What is it? "The more you try to grasp this Dhamma, the more it slips away; the more you let go, the more it is grasped." Now, this child was trying to grasp the Dhamma; he hoped to grasp a word of Dhamma, go home, and get that gold. But when he tried to 'grasp' the word of Dhamma, the Dhamma slipped away. Now, as he let this go—as he let go of the desire for the gold—then he began to grasp the word of Dhamma. From this, we can understand that what helps us to understand this entire Dhamma is letting go. What is done through all things, such as giving alms (*dāna*) and keeping precepts (*sīla*), is letting go. As you let go and let go, the Dhamma is grasped. That is what ultimately, through such a great revolution of the mind, contributed to Kāla obtaining such a supramundane state—the state of Stream-entry. He might also be someone who had practiced meditation in past lives.

Even though he lived in that manner during the early part of this life due to some unfortunate cause, we can understand that through the Blessed One's skillful strategy, those insight-knowledges (*vipassanā-ñāṇa*) emerged within this child, and he obtained the noble fruit of Stream-entry (*Sotāpatti-phala*).

Now, from this story, we can bring out several very valuable points. Firstly, when reflecting on the strategy used by the treasurer Anāthapiṇḍika, it is a good example for parents of this era too. On a Poya day, he used a certain strategy to bring his child closer to the Triple Gem. Indeed, the inheritance one must give to one's children is the inheritance of faith (*saddhā*) and the inheritance of Dhamma. In that way, the treasurer Anāthapiṇḍika tried to bring his child close to the Triple Gem, even by putting money on the line—by giving a promise of money. That is also a good example.

Likewise, there is also an example here that we can take into our lives. What is it? We can extract Nibbāna from the very life problems presented to us. The problem present before Kāla's life was to somehow grasp a word of Dhamma and obtain that gold. Through that very problem, that child extracted Nibbāna. To do that, some transformation must occur within the mind. Life problems exist for everyone—for every person. They face various disasters and adversities. But the world does not know how to obtain those noble states through them. For that, some special transformation must occur. Firstly, a change must occur in the way we look at the world. That is called attitude. The Blessed One has shown that way of looking. How does the ordinary worldly person look at the world? "Anicce nicca-saññā"—there is a nature in the world of considering the impermanent as permanent, of recognizing the impermanent as permanent. Likewise, "Dukkhe sukha-saññā"—thinking that what is full of Suffering (*dukkha*) is pleasure—such an understanding, such a feeling exists in the world. "Asubhe subha-saññā"—that is, even though there is nothing that can be taken as beautiful, or as good and pure, they appear as beautiful. Likewise, "Anatte atta-saññā"—even what cannot be taken as self, as "myself" or "mine," is taken as "myself" and "mine." The Blessed One declared that there are four such wrong understandings in the world. They are called the "perversions of perception" (*vipallāsa-dhamma*)—distorted ideas. Distorted ideas mean entirely wrong ideas, as if turned upside down. Therefore, in place of that, what Buddhists must do is always strive to develop that correct attitude. How is that correct way? One must practice contemplating the impermanent as Impermanent (*anicca*). One must practice contemplating the foul as foul. One must train the mind to think that what is Not-self (*anattā*)—what cannot be taken as "myself" or "mine"—is not mine.

Now, that is exactly what happened within that child. While listening to the Dhamma, he first thought this was a permanent thing, a pleasant thing; thinking in that way, he began to listen to the Dhamma with a great desire and expectation for that bag of gold coins. But later, due to the Blessed One's strategy, that understanding gradually came: "There is nothing to be taken here. This is Impermanent (*anicca*), full of Suffering (*dukkha*), there is nothing beautiful. There is nothing here to be taken as mine." Thus, a change occurred in the way he looked at the world. Next, something similar—in order to extract the Dhamma from our life problems—is what is called reflection. We direct our mind to all these things and try to obtain an understanding of them—reflection. This reflection too is often done in a wrong way in the world. The Blessed One refers to this as unwise attention (*ayoniso manasikāra*). Unwise attention (*ayoniso manasikāra*), if we express it in a commonly understood word, is improper reflection, improper—or inappropriate—reflecting in a way that is not correct. The illustration for that is: here, when the Blessed One was preaching the Dhamma, this child first began to reflect on the word of Dhamma keeping the bag of gold coins in mind. In the depths of his mind—at the back of his mind—is the thought of the bag of gold coins. When reflecting on the word of Dhamma with the intention of obtaining the bag of gold coins in this way, the word of Dhamma is not caught correctly. That is wrong reflection. Most people in the world reflect in a wrong way when they reflect on various things. But proper reflection is Wise attention (*yoniso manasikāra*). Thinking that all of these are things that arise from within, that "here there is only a pile of Feeling (*vedanā*) experiences, a pile of perceptions, a pile of expectations, a pile of impacts, a pile of reflections"—that "here there is only earth, water, fire, and wind, which are these four elements." In this way, reflecting on their true nature, on things as they really are. That is what needs to be developed. This reflection, gradually developed, helps one to realize Nibbāna. We must abandon our wrong reflection and practice reflecting in the correct manner.

Likewise, there is another thing—something connected to this very reflection. Generally, when people of the world reflect on various things, they try to grasp them tightly—this is called misapprehension (*parāmāsa*). During the time of the Blessed One, there were also some people who believed that by living as cattle, by keeping precepts in that way, they could realize Nibbāna, or escape from saṃsāra. This is called misapprehension (*parāmāsa*). But in this Dhamma, the correct way of directing the mind to various things is shown as comprehension (*sammasana*). In meditation, that reflection is done by the mind—like "touching" with the mind, like "feeling" with the mind. To understand this, let us return to the simile of the banana trunk. That person mentioned earlier—the person who saw the banana trunk for the first time—carried the

banana tree on his shoulder, embracing it, thinking, "There is a core in this." This embracing, grasping in this way, is called misapprehension (*parāmāsa*). Doing it in that way, one can never see Nibbāna. One cannot be freed from this Suffering (*dukkha*). What is there to do instead? It is when, after peeling off one sheath of that banana trunk, one feels it subtly, that one finds there is a next sheath. Grasping one sheath, next one feels gently. As that sheath ends, another sheath, and beneath that, another sheath. In this way, one feels subtly. This is comprehension (*sammasana*). This is not physical touching, but rather, what the meditator does is touching with the mind, contacting with the mind. Gold, silver, pearls, gems, trees, stones, beds, chairs, tables, and so on—regarding all of these, understanding first comes in accordance with the names given to them in the world, in accordance with the values given to them: "A very valuable thing that must be in every home." In this way, as desire grows in the world, one grasps it with the mind. But when reflecting slowly, what is present here? The understanding comes that "this is an empty thing, a hollow thing." One realizes, in the end, that it is only something created from within the mind, only something embraced by the mind. Just as when one feels that banana trunk slowly, sheath by sheath, one understands in the end that there is no core, similarly, here there is only a pile of thoughts, a pile of thoughts. There is nothing to be taken as "myself" or "mine." A multitude of thoughts arise and cease.

It is when one thinks and reflects in that way that this Dhamma is understood most deeply. The Blessed One has declared the Four Noble Truths—the entire saṃsāric existence, this five-aggregate bundle of form, Feeling (*vedanā*), perception, Formations (*saṅkhāra*), and Consciousness (*viññāṇa*), is Impermanent (*anicca*), Suffering (*dukkha*), and Not-self (*anattā*). All of these are full of Suffering (*dukkha*). The Truth of Suffering (*dukkha-sacca*). The truth regarding Suffering (*dukkha*) in the world. This Suffering (*dukkha*) arises because of the Craving (*taṇhā*) that the world has towards this. It was because of the Craving (*taṇhā*) that child had towards that bag of gold coins that such a Suffering (*dukkha*) arose, when he went to listen to that word of Dhamma. Then, the understanding of that Suffering (*dukkha*) arose. Beneath that Suffering (*dukkha*) is Craving (*taṇhā*). The state where this Craving (*taṇhā*) is destroyed, where it is appeased, is Nibbāna. When that child abandoned the desire for the bag of gold coins and then the Dhamma began to be understood, Nibbāna was realized. What helps in that is what is called the Noble Eightfold Path: right view (*sammā-diṭṭhi*), right intention (*sammā-saṅkappa*), right speech (*sammā-vācā*), right action (*sammā-kammanta*), right livelihood (*sammā-ājīva*), right effort (*sammā-vāyāma*), right mindfulness (*sammā-sati*), and right concentration (*sammā-samādhi*). That is, this right view, right thoughts and intentions that go in accordance with right

view, right action that goes in accordance with right thoughts, right livelihood that goes in accordance with right action, right effort—striving—the effort to purify the mind in accordance with right livelihood, and the right mindfulness—called *sati*—that arises through that, and the right concentration (*samyak-samādhi*)—the right one-pointedness of mind, composure—that arises based on that mindfulness. In this way, the Eightfold Path is that fourth truth. It is through the understanding of these Four Noble Truths that anyone—be they great or small, be they a seven-year-old child or a sixty- or seventy-year-old person—attains the paths and fruits. Through deeply understanding such profound Dhamma in this way. This is not something expressed in words, but a Dhamma to be understood entirely within. When reflecting accordingly on the benefits that can be taken into life from this Dhamma, if they have understood them correctly, anyone can raise all of them into meditation and attention (*manasikāra*) in their daily lives, within their everyday life problems. They can include a multitude of virtues that help towards Nibbāna—a multitude of meritorious phenomena born of meditation—within their mental continuum. Thus, this is the example to be taken from the Dhamma story of the young child named Kāla.

Even though many things in this world appear dark, they can be made white if one abandons that wrong understanding in this Dhamma—abandoning the wrong reflection called unwise attention (*ayoniso manasikāra*)—and trains in the direction of correct understanding, called Wise attention (*yoniso manasikāra*). If one abandons that attitude of looking at the world in a wrong way and trains in looking at the world in the correct way, then that person can, perhaps even in the midst of their daily activities, extract subjects of meditation (*kammaṭṭhāna*) from within them and obtain the realization of the paths and fruits. In various stories of the Buddha's time, it is mentioned that some elders (*theras* and *therīs*), some members of the Saṅgha, attained Arahantship upon seeing a lamp being extinguished—when they went to sleep and tried to reduce and extinguish the flame of a lamp. Some saw a forest fire, some saw a mass of foam floating on water, and seeing various such things, they realized Nibbāna through them. Through every single one of them, they developed a deep understanding of the world. Using one example present in the world, when the ability to wisely think, "other things are just like this too," arises, then that person can obtain the realization of the supramundane paths and fruits. At this time, just as during the Buddha's time, or perhaps even more, various kinds of Suffering (*dukkha*), hardships, and disasters are heard of in this world and society. One can extract Nibbāna through them.

Likewise, regarding the bag of gold coins mentioned about Kāla—just like that bag of gold coins, in this era too, one hears so much along the roads about 'jackpots' (*jaya-malu*) and 'fortune bags' (*vāsana-malu*). There must be

thousands, lakhs of people who buy tickets hoping for these jackpots and fortune bags. Not everyone wins these jackpots and fortune bags. It does not matter if they are not obtained. Through them, just as that child Kāla did, one must try to draw closer to the Dhamma. What is present here? Whether this jackpot, this fortune bag is obtained or not, this is the nature of this life. Everything is Impermanent (*anicca*). Every effort made in pursuit of impermanent things is full of Suffering (*dukkha*). If the truth in the world is such, there is nothing here to be taken as "myself" or "mine." There is no essence, no core. All of these must be abandoned at the moment of death. All those collections of wealth, relatives, and friends, which were taken as "myself" and "mine," must be abandoned and left behind. In the end, the relatives gather and hang a banner: "Aniccā vata saṅkhārā" or "Sabbē saṅkhārā aniccā." When they hang them, that person has already died. There is no time to make an effort towards those supramundane states. Everything—the entire life—is a series of designs, a series of preparations, as we said. It is just like some people who are preparing to go on a journey and sometimes see a dream. Just like preparing to go on a great journey, a pilgrimage or a pleasure trip. They prepare, but something is missing. They run back and complete that too—regarding clothes and ornaments. While doing so, suddenly they wake up, and they do not even get to go on the journey. Such is the thing done throughout the entire life. From young child to old man, the entire life is a series of designs and preparations. But the nature of Suffering (*dukkha*) within this is not understood. Just like the person who carried the banana trunk, the pile of sheaths present there is not seen. To see that pile of sheaths is why we meditate. As the mind becomes calmer and calmer, it is seen: "Here there are only these phenomena—Feeling (*vedanā*), perception, volition, Contact (*phassa*), and attention—only this much is present." What are called earth, water, fire, and wind—both external things in this world and our bodies—all of these are only the four elements of which they are constructed. There is nothing beyond this. "For an infinite time in saṃsāra, we have run in pursuit of these. Here there is only running, only Craving (*taṇhā*), only thirst." Such an understanding arises to one.

It is when that understanding has arisen that, as the Blessed One declared, one can obtain that state of Stream-entry, which is superior to even the empire of a wheel-turning monarch, superior to going to heaven, superior to lordship over the entire world. If one has obtained that state, one will be reborn at most seven times. Developing further the Noble Eightfold Path one has entered, and meditating even deeper, that person can obtain the second path and fruit, called Once-returning (*Sakadāgāmi*), leaving only one more return to this world, escaping from the rest of saṃsāric Suffering (*dukkha*). If they develop meditation even deeper beyond that, by turning once again that Wheel of

Dhamma they set in motion, they arrive at the state of Non-returning (*Anāgāmi*), and without returning to this world, they can realize Nibbāna in the Brahma world itself. Striving even further beyond that, meditating deeply, one can completely destroy these defilements and free oneself from the entire saṃsāric Suffering (*dukkha*) of Birth (*jāti*), Aging and Death (*jarāmaraṇa*), and disease, finding peace in the noble and supreme Nibbāna.

Thus, through the story of this treasurer's son named Kāla, we were able to establish our minds on the path to Nibbāna. We can say without fear that if one goes very deep into even a single word of Dhamma preached by the Blessed One, Nibbāna is present there. If we take one drop from this ocean of Dhamma of the Blessed One, in every single one of them there is the taste of liberation (*vimuttirasa*), the taste of Nibbāna. Just as a drop of water taken from anywhere in the great ocean has the taste of salt, even if we take one small word of Dhamma from the ocean of Dhamma, through it we can direct our minds all the way to Nibbāna. For someone who has developed the objects of meditation in saṃsāra, they can realize Nibbāna even at the moment of listening to the Dhamma.

The Blessed One has declared that the realization of the paths and fruits can be obtained not only on the meditation seat, but at five places. They are called the "bases of liberation" (*vimuttāyatana*). Liberation (*vimukti*) means freedom—freedom from saṃsāra. Bases (*āyatana*) mean a certain center, a place where one can obtain that freedom. Five such places are shown. What are those five places? One can realize liberation when listening to the Dhamma. It was when listening to the Dhamma that this child named Kāla realized Nibbāna. When listening to the Dhamma, directing the mind well to it, when the moment of deep reflection arrives, one can obtain that supramundane state. Another can do so when preaching the Dhamma—while preaching the Dhamma, when maintaining the mind on the Dhamma... Just as when preparing food for guests, it is not only the guests who can partake, but others too can satisfy their hunger; in the same way, it is shown that some members of the Saṅgha obtained realization at the moment of preaching the Dhamma. Likewise, when reflecting on the Dhamma—when reflecting on a deep point of the Dhamma in solitude, suddenly a correct and deep understanding arrives, and one can realize Nibbāna through such a realization of the paths and fruits. For some others, when reciting the Dhamma—when reciting the Dhamma with the mind well-directed, then too, the mind becomes calm and concentrated, a deep understanding of it arrives, and they can obtain those fruits like Stream-entry. They can also become Arahants. Finally, what is shown is taking some sign of concentration (*samādhi-nimitta*)—which is what is generally considered as meditation in the world—and by developing meditation systematically based on some sign of concentration, one can also realize liberation. In this way, if one engages in activities like listening to the

Dhamma, preaching the Dhamma, and reflecting on the Dhamma in daily life, one can realize those paths and fruits. Accordingly, we must strive in our daily lives to take the benefits that can be obtained from this Dhamma into our own lives, in light of this story.

Today, then, this virtuous gathering has accumulated a vast amount of merit (*kusala*) on this occasion by listening to this Dhamma. Listening to the Dhamma is not merely an ordinary custom; if one listens to the Dhamma directing the mind to Nibbāna, it becomes a strong supportive condition (*upanissaya*) for Nibbāna. That we obtained this human existence, and developed a fondness and inclination for the Dhamma, is because we developed these as habits over a long period of time. Therefore, even for saṃsāra, listening to this Dhamma is helpful. On those various occasions, if someone strives, they can, like that child Kāla, obtain the noble realization of the paths and fruits through a single word of Dhamma. Therefore, on this occasion, you have observed the precepts and listened to the Dhamma. You have generated a vast accumulation of meritorious thoughts. You have accumulated a great deal of merit. Strive to make this merit of listening to the Dhamma, this merit, this wholesome condition, a support to realize the supreme bliss of Nibbāna, by gradually attaining the paths and fruits beginning with Stream-entry (*Sotāpatti*) in this very life.

Likewise, may you share this accumulated mass of merit with the guardian deities of the Dispensation, and whatever deities, spirits, and other beings reside in this place, so that they all may rejoice in it and find peace in the supreme, noble Nibbāna, which is free from decay and death (*ajarāmarā*).

Similarly, if there are any departed relatives, friends, and others who have passed away, and whatever beings in this world-system, from Avīci hell up to the Akanitha heaven, who are hoping for Nibbāna—may they all rejoice in this noble merit and, being freed from all saṃsāric Suffering (*dukkha*) of Birth (*jāti*), Aging and Death (*jarāmarāṇa*), and disease, find peace in the supreme, noble Nibbāna, which is free from decay and death (*ajarāmarā*). Wishing thus, now recite these verses and share the merit.

“*Ettāvatā ca amhehi.....*”